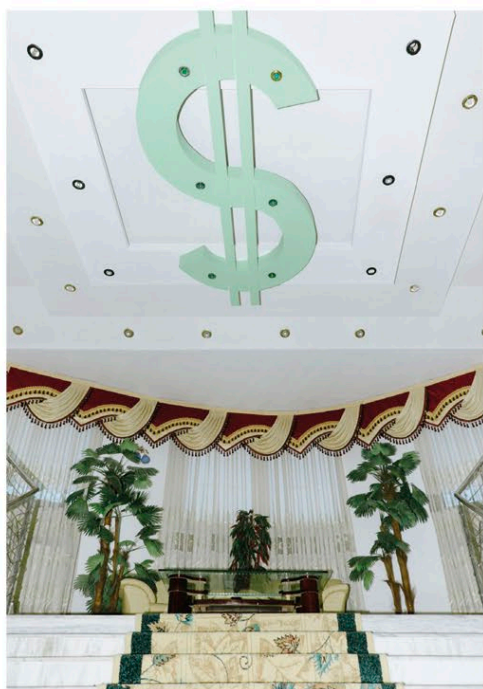




#### ▲ Symbol of wealth

This Romanian altar applies the principle of commonality: as the dollar sign is green, green trappings around the altar are thought to increase the success of magic spells to attain greater wealth.

“Neopaganism is ... the worship of the powers of this world. Beautiful, terrible, but all in a circle under the turning sky.”

C.A. BURLAND, *ECHOES OF MAGIC*, 1972

#### Making magic work

Neopagans regard magic as a real phenomenon that they can harness. For some, the aim of using magic is to change their consciousness and, ultimately, to contact gods, spirits, or whatever they regard as sacred. Others use magic to attempt to align natural forces in the world with their will in order to bring

about change—a practice called thaumaturgy. Whatever the goal, one rule is sacrosanct: magic must never be used to harm people, animals, plants, or the planet. Moreover, according to the threefold law (also called Rule of Three), however much magical force—positive or negative—a practitioner generates, three times as much of that same magic will return to them, so this power needs to be handled ethically. Magicians practicing thaumaturgy believe they are most likely to achieve the change they seek if it follows natural laws: for

example, a ritual appeal to a fertility god in the springtime to help make the garden bloom has a good chance of success. Magic can be performed with a specific goal in mind, such as moving to a particular house or flat, but is said to be more likely to work when the goal is broader: for instance, to find a home that fulfills certain criteria.

#### Typical rituals

Most Neopagans celebrate the eight Sabbats (the Wiccan festivals): the winter and summer solstices, the fall and spring equinoxes, the cross-quarter days (which, according to ancient Celts, marked the start of a season) in between, and other auspicious dates, such as the monthly full moon. Rituals may be solitary, conducted at home or in a

#### ▼ The magic of fire

The dominant pagan faith in Lithuania is Romuva. It places strong emphasis on fire as a symbol of the divine. Here, the summer solstice is celebrated in Vilnius, the capital city.

